Just Enough to Keep You Out of Jail

This is not legal advice. We are not lawyers. This is the short list of things student teams actually trip over — the 20% that prevents 80% of the mess. When real money or real personal data starts flowing, buy one hour with a real lawyer (the startup legal office hours are free — book them).

1. Recording interviews

Ask BEFORE you hit record. One sentence is enough:

> "Ich würde das Gespräch gerne aufnehmen, nur für unsere interne Auswertung — ist das okay?" / "I'd like to record this for our internal notes only — is that okay?"

Get a yes on the recording. Store recordings privately (team drive, not public), don't share clips outside the team, delete if someone asks. That's it.

2. Your landing page

You're collecting emails in Germany. Three things, thirty minutes:

- **Impressum** — legally required on German websites, even test pages. Use a generator (e.g. e-recht24), paste, done.
- **Privacy line** near the form: "We store your email only to contact you about [product]. No sharing, unsubscribe anytime, contact: [email]." If your form tool offers double opt-in, turn it on.
- **Don't** buy email lists, scrape addresses, or import your interviewees into a mailing tool without asking them.

Analytics: prefer a cookieless EU tool (e.g. Plausible) and you can skip the cookie banner circus entirely.

3. Taking money

Covered properly in Module 09. The survival version: an invoice needs 7 fields (both names & addresses, date, invoice number, description, amount, your §19 no-VAT note if you're under the Kleinunternehmer limits). A team taking money together with no setup is a **GbR — you are all personally liable**. Fine for pilots; revisit when real risk shows up.

4. The email list after the course

The consents you collected are for THIS product. If you kill the idea: delete the list. If you pivot: ask again ("we've changed direction — still want updates?"). Don't carry lists into your next project like furniture.

5. Other people's stuff

Don't paste competitor screenshots into your product, don't use unlicensed images/fonts on your landing page (use Unsplash/Pexels-style licensed sources), don't copy someone's pricing page word-for-word. Code from your own laptop is yours; code built on university lab infrastructure or in a paid job — check first (TUM ForTe / Venture Labs answer this for free).

When to actually get help

Any of these = book the (free) legal office hour BEFORE proceeding: handling health or financial data · customers demanding a signed contract you don't understand · first employee or intern · incorporation (UG/GmbH) · anyone threatening you with anything.

Checklist, not counsel. Updated July 2026.